

Unified Network for Nurturing Adaptive & Transformative Rural Initiative (UNNATI) Workshop

CATALYSING CLIMATE-RESILIENT RURAL GROWTH FOR INDIA

UDAIPUR 26-28 MARCH 2026



Context

Background

India aspires to become a USD 30 trillion economy by 2047. Rural systems will prove to be a significant driver for this growth with a third of its population located in rural geographies. Climate risks, socio-economic vulnerabilities, fragmented markets, weak institutions, and limited access to finance continue to, however, plague rural growth. While promising solutions exist, they have often remained siloed, limiting their ability to scale and deliver system-wide impact. Addressing this systemic issue requires coordinated, place-based action grounded in local context and supported by aligned investments.

Objective

This initiative was designed to build a unified network of funders and practitioners to enable an adaptive and transformative shift in India's rural development trajectory, termed UNNATI. The workshop was convened within this context to foster alignment, surface critical barriers and opportunities, and catalyse coordinated action toward climate-resilient rural transformation.

Flow of the workshop

The two-day workshop convened a diverse set of stakeholders from the funding ecosystem, including global and domestic philanthropies, CSR-aligned funders, and private sector actors engaged in rural value chains. It surfaced key challenges shaping rural systems and explored collaborative pathways forward. **Day 1** examined the state of rural India, highlighting structural gaps driven by urban-centric frameworks that misalign policy, finance, and institutional approaches. **Day 2** focused on solutions, aligning philanthropic actors toward a coordinated coalition while grounding strategies in practical, field-level insights from on-ground practitioners.

Aligning on roadblocks to rural growth and the way ahead

Despite diverse stakeholders and funding priorities, the workshop revealed strong alignment on the key barriers to rural growth. While nuances exist, the core problem was identified as the lack of place-based design, decision-making, capacity, and ownership. It also underscored the need for solutions to be grounded in a deeper understanding of the structural and systemic realities shaping rural landscapes.

Key

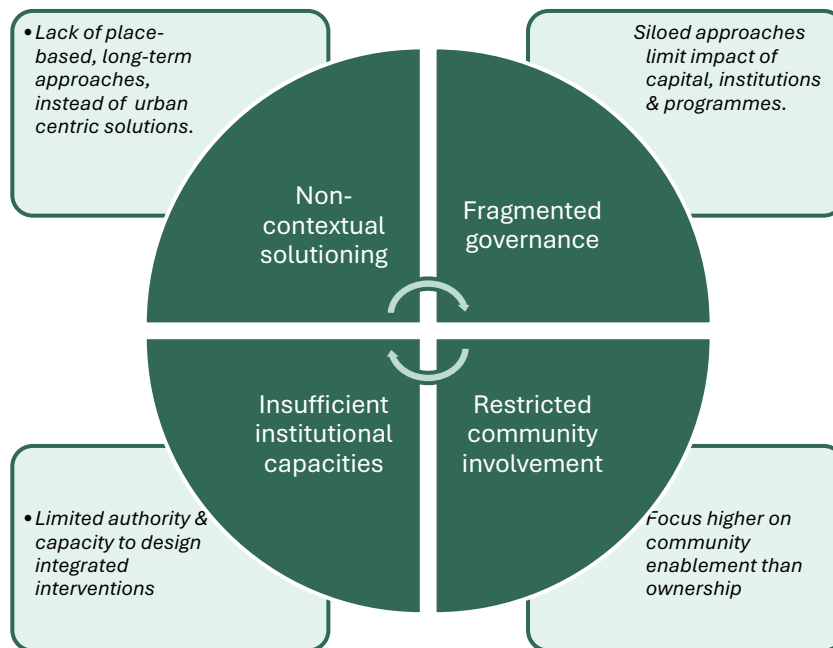


Figure 1: Roadblocks to rural growth

considerations included:

- Addressing interconnected constraints such as limited access to long-term capital, a bias toward short-term credit, weak market alignment, and inadequate infrastructure and enabling assets.
- Ensuring solutions are place-based and grounded in local contexts, with communities positioned as co-creators rather than beneficiaries.
- Evolving funding structures beyond fragmented, short-term approaches toward derisked models that accommodate varying risk appetites, impact priorities, and modes of engagement.

There was strong consensus on the need to shift toward place-based, system-driven approaches anchored in community ownership, long-term capital, and institutional alignment.

Constituting a Unified Network for Transformation (UNNATI)

UNNATI is, thus, an initiative taken by Energiva to create a common platform that aligns different capital sources with different outcome appetite and visibility. This platform bases its solutions on four interconnected levers—**financing**, **markets**, **institutions** and **communities**. The platform layers philanthropic and private capital for collective impact while preserving funders’ thematic flexibility. UNNATI aligns these investments into a coherent, place-based strategy so that contributions reinforce rather than operate in isolation. This integrated approach unlocks greater impact by combining capital, expertise, and interventions to deliver sustained, scalable outcomes at the

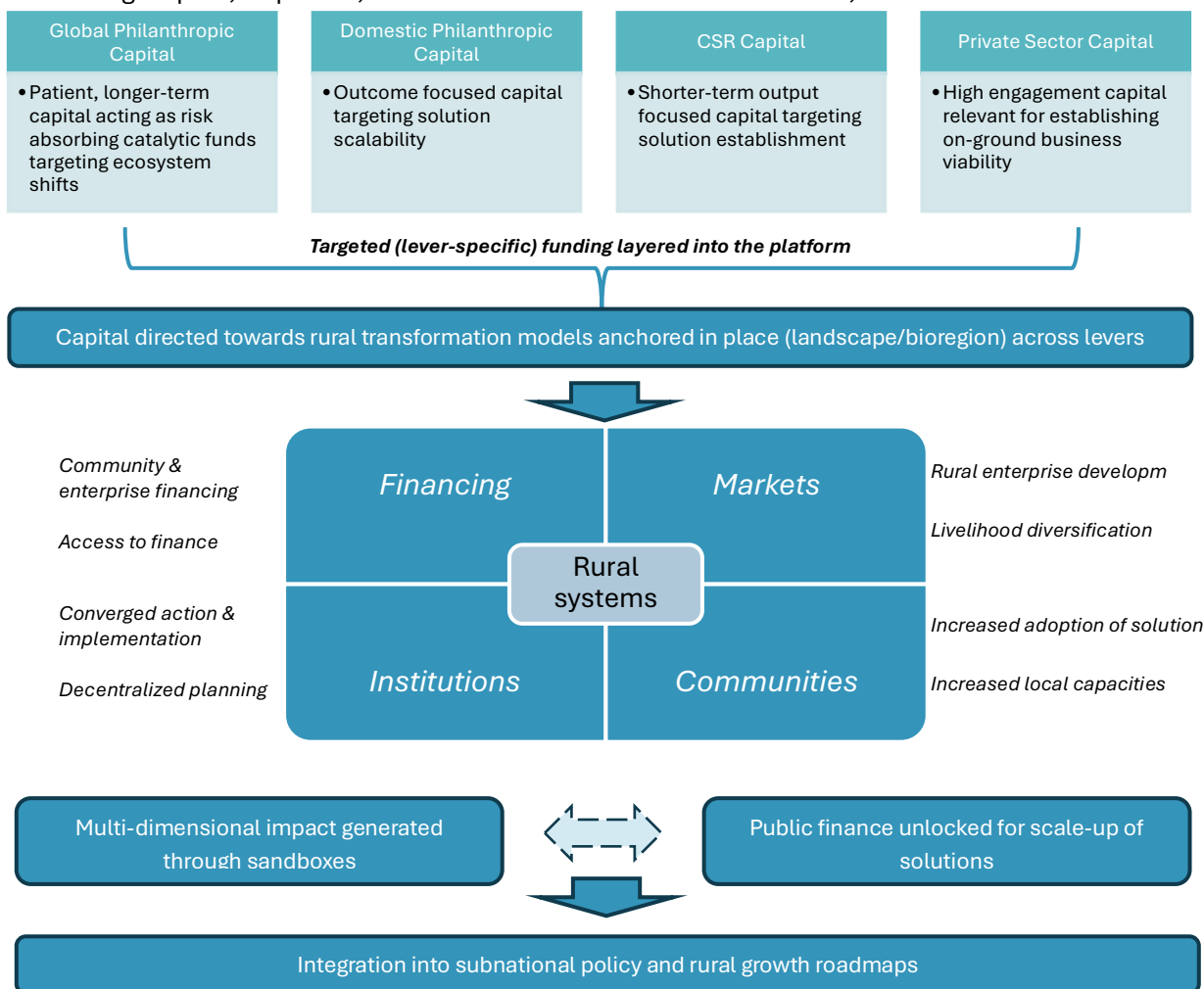


Figure 2: Operational model of UNNATI

landscape level.

Alignment with Philanthropic Perspectives and Priorities

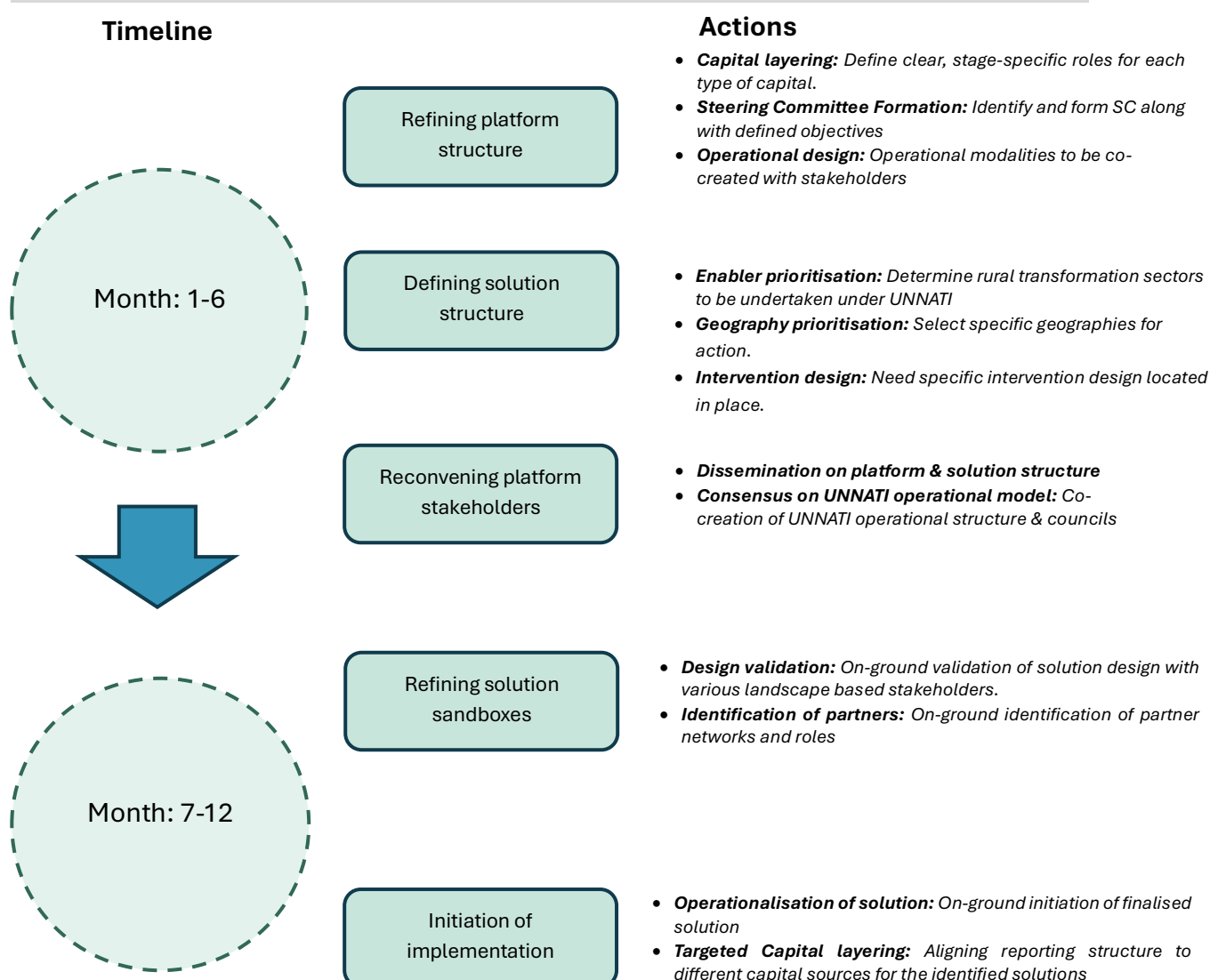
UNNATI’s structure is designed to respond to the priorities of CSR, domestic, and global philanthropies through a flexible, layered platform that aligns capital and action within a shared place-based vision. The workshop discussions reinforced this fit. For **CSR and private sector actors**, who often require shorter-term, output-oriented models, UNNATI offers a framework centred on measurable outcomes and value chain alignment, helping connect business priorities with rural development outcomes. For **domestic philanthropies**, the platform responds to the need for clearer problem-to-solution pathways and stronger on-ground execution, while also enabling catalytic use of capital to build scalable and investable pipelines. For **global philanthropy**, platform creates space

for long-term, patient capital to support interventions that move beyond isolated pilots toward institutional adoption, while also enabling the convergence of mitigation priorities in ways that remain grounded in landscape realities and embed resilience into the design.

During the discussion, it was also noted that UNNATI aligns well with the existing efforts of leading philanthropies like Rainmatter Foundation's **Livelihood Network model**, which frames solutions not as isolated interventions but as part of an integrated, place-based solution stack which includes the 6M Model - manpower, machinery, money, material, method, market. The model helps build livelihoods through the alignment of markets, institutions, and community capabilities rather than through standalone programs which strongly resonated with UNNATI's own framework.

These perspectives supported a more integrated, grounded, and scalable pathway for taking UNNATI forward.

Charting the way ahead (Reflections from the workshop)



Annexure 1: Workshop Participants

UNNATI Workshop Attendees

Philanthropies:

- Reliance Foundation
- Heifer International
- Children's Investment Fund Foundation
- McCormick & Company
- Oak Foundation
- Rockefeller Foundation
- Hindustan Unilever Limited
- Rainmatter Foundation

Partners:

- Intellectcap Advisory Services
- Consumer Unity & Trust Society (CUTS) International
- Transform Rural India Foundation
- Digital Green Trust
- Mirava
- Seva Mandir
- Goonj Foundation
- Arpan Seva Sansthan
- Vidya Bhawan Krishi Vigyan Kendra, Udaipur